

Designing for an AI-Augmented Journaling Experience: Balancing Guidance and Autonomy for Deeper Emotional Insight

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Abstract

Journaling has long been recognized as a valuable avenue for self-reflection and emotional well-being, yet sustaining meaningful engagement can be difficult. In this paper, we explore the possibilities and pitfalls of integrating LLM-driven features, emotional dissection, semantic retrieval, and conversational prompting, into a personal informatics-focused journaling system. Through an autobiographical design approach, we iteratively designed with a prototype that leverages large language models and reflective informatics principles, probing how AI and data might enrich users' introspection without undermining their autonomy. Our findings demonstrate the benefits of holistic tracking and visualization in reinforcing consistent journaling habits, while also uncovering key tensions between automated guidance and self-directed reflection. By interlacing personal informatics with AI-driven prompts, we reveal new opportunities for enhancing emotional awareness, fostering sustained journaling practices, and uncovering long-term patterns. Additionally, we highlight privacy concerns and ethical considerations in handling sensitive personal data under the context of AI. We conclude by suggesting directions for future research in AI-supported personal informatics and journaling tools.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**; *Usability testing*; *Collaborative and social computing systems and tools*.

Keywords

Journaling, AI-Augmented Reflection, Personal Informatics, Human-AI Interaction

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1 Introduction

Resilience, the capacity to positively adapt to adversity and foster personal growth, draws upon various internal factors, such as self-efficacy, optimism, emotional intelligence, and self-care [12]. Research shows that structured self-reflection enhances these factors by cultivating deeper awareness of one's responses to stress and adversity [9, 10]. Journaling, in particular, has long been recognized as a powerful vehicle for self-reflection and emotional processing [2]. Through consistent written exploration of daily events and stressors, individuals can develop "coping insights", nuanced understandings of how personal beliefs, emotions, and contexts shape one's capacity to adapt under pressure [10].

Despite the well-documented benefits of journaling, challenges persist in maintaining ongoing engagement and eliciting deeper insights. Li et al. [17] describe how personal informatics (PI) systems often fail to effectively guide users beyond data collection into richer stages of reflection and action. Similarly, Epstein et al. [8] highlight how lapses in tracking and discontinuities in use can hamper the development of meaningful self-knowledge. While reflective practices can foster positive growth, Eikey et al. [7] caution that unstructured or superficial reflection risks devolving into rumination, persistent negative thought cycles detrimental to well-being.

Recent research points to the potential of AI tools for tackling these hurdles. Advances in human-AI interaction (HAI) emphasize strategies for maintaining user agency, transparency, and trust, which are key elements when integrating AI into sensitive domains such as mental health and personal growth [20, 21]. By offering capabilities such as AI-assisted tagging, semantic search, and adaptive prompting, AI systems can scaffold self-reflection in new ways, but only if designed to preserve user autonomy and avoid over-reliance [22]. DiaryMate [15] and ExploreSelf [19] are examples of AI-driven journaling, demonstrating how large language models (LLMs) can help reveal emotional patterns and alternative perspectives. Many existing AI-based journaling tools focus primarily on AI-assisted reflection within each individual journaling or reflection interaction. This ignores the power of integrating personal informatics that offers a longitudinal perspective on users' emotional trajectories. Recent work in human-AI interaction interfaces further underscores important design trade-offs: preserving user autonomy [15], preventing shallow engagement [14], and addressing ethical implications related to privacy and data handling [13].

With these considerations, we examine an AI-augmented journaling system through an autobiographical lens to investigate some key questions:

- **How can we design human-AI collaboration in journaling to deepen and enrich self-reflection?**

- **How can we balance AI-generated suggestions with user autonomy to prevent over-reliance?**
- **How can we use personal informatics to provide a holistic view of journaling data and emotional patterns?**

We propose a novel AI-enhanced journaling system grounded in personal informatics, reflective informatics, and human-AI interaction insights from similar tools, lived with by the first author through an autobiographical design [5, 6, 14]. Our approach attempts to treat AI and tools as *collaborative facilitators*, ensuring that users retain full control over how and when they engage with AI while reaping the benefits of conveniences from automation. Our system integrates emotion-based tagging that leads to holistic personal informatics, and LLM-driven agentic interactions in a manner that preserves user agency. Through an iterative design process and autobiographical evaluation, we show how AI can meaningfully support journaling while respecting individual autonomy, ultimately offering new avenues for reflection, growth, and well-being.

2 Background

2.1 Human-AI Interaction

Human-AI interaction research explores how AI can complement human capabilities in domains ranging from creativity and decision-making to emotional reflection [20, 21]. Central challenges include balancing AI’s adaptive nature with user control, designing transparent systems that clarify uncertainties in AI outputs, and ensuring users of varying expertise can effectively engage with AI tools [22]. Recent advances underscore the importance of “collaborative intelligence,” where humans contribute leadership and ethical judgment, while AI delivers speed and scalability [20]. While designing effective Human-AI interaction is difficult, iterative design practices, such as prototyping AI behaviors in Wizard of Oz studies, help developers anticipate user needs and system errors before full implementation [21].

2.2 Personal Informatics

Personal informatics (PI) systems gather and present self-tracked data to foster self-awareness and behavior change [8, 17]. Li et al. [17] propose a five-stage model for personal informatics (preparation, collection, integration, reflection, and action), highlighting how barriers in earlier stages can cascade and undermine deeper introspection. Their framework shows that meaningful change hinges on seamless transitions from data capture to insight generation. By supporting each stage holistically, personal informatics systems can more effectively guide users toward actionable self-knowledge. Epstein et al. [8] introduced the Lived Informatics Model, recognizing lapses and resumption in tracking as common challenges. Strategies such as purposeful journaling and data visualization can promote healthy, goal-oriented introspection [1]. However, there are also pitfalls in design and usage of personal informatics systems. While reflection aids insight, excessive self-focus can lead to rumination, a vicious cycle of negative thoughts [7].

2.3 Reflection and AI Design

Designing technologies to support deeper reflection requires a careful blend of interactive features and user-centric philosophies. Baumer’s reflective informatics framework proposes that systems can encourage breakdowns (moments of doubt), structured inquiry, and transformations that alter one’s perspective [3]. Hallnäs and Redström’s slow technology philosophy similarly promotes gradual, mindful interactions that invite pause and contemplation [11]. In the context of self-monitoring, tools like SleepTight demonstrate how lightweight prompts and positive framing nurture reflective analysis of personal behaviors [4]. More recently, AI-empowered journaling systems have shown promise in helping users revisit past experiences and uncover meaningful connections. DiaryMate and MindfulDiary leverage large language models (LLMs) to help people write or use conversations to improve their well-being through journaling [15, 16]. The Mindscape App integrates time series data into journaling on top of LLM queries [18]. ExploreSelf [19] extends this framework by fostering user-driven exploration and reflection with adaptive AI guidance. Unlike traditional structured journaling or therapy chatbots, ExploreSelf allows users to maintain control over their reflective journey by dynamically navigating AI-generated themes, Socratic questions, and adaptive feedback.

3 System Overview

The *Personal Growth Journal* (Figure 1) is a web-based application designed to facilitate introspection and personal development through LLM guided journaling and insights. Rather than functioning as an automated writing tool, the system emphasizes reflective agency, placing users in control of their self-discovery process. By integrating concepts from human-AI collaboration [20], reflective informatics [3], and staged personal informatics model [17], the system supports meaningful engagement while avoiding the pitfalls of AI over-reliance [15].

3.1 Journaling Environment

The *Journaling Environment* supports user-driven journaling sessions through integrated features that preserve user agency and prompt introspection:

- **Journal Entries and Emotional Tracking:** Users can input daily or ad hoc reflections. When the user clicks the Detect Tags button in the top-left corner (Figure 2), the system suggests possible emotional tags (e.g., “anxiety,” “joy”) based on the text content. Users can accept, reject, or refine these tags in settings, ensuring full control. Tags are visually distinguished through customizable color-coding, helping users track and reflect on emotional states over time. Tagging serves as an early stage in personal informatics [17], influencing the later stages in effectiveness of personal informatics. This makes a crucial part of the system.
- **Psychologically Provocative Prompts:** Drawing on an entry’s content, the system presents reflective questions to encourage deeper introspection. For example, as shown in the solid box in Figure 2, a question like, “What would it look like to approach my work tasks with curiosity instead of fear, and how might this shift impact my overall sense

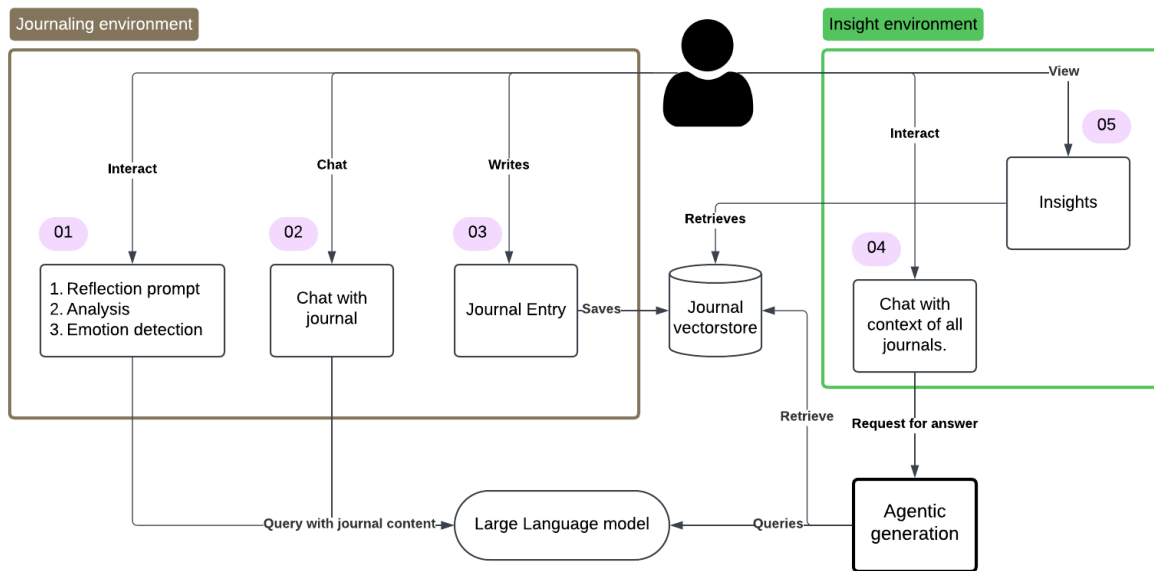


Figure 1: System flow diagram. Users write daily entries, receive AI-driven emotional tag suggestions, and can optionally engage in LLM-based chats for deeper reflection.

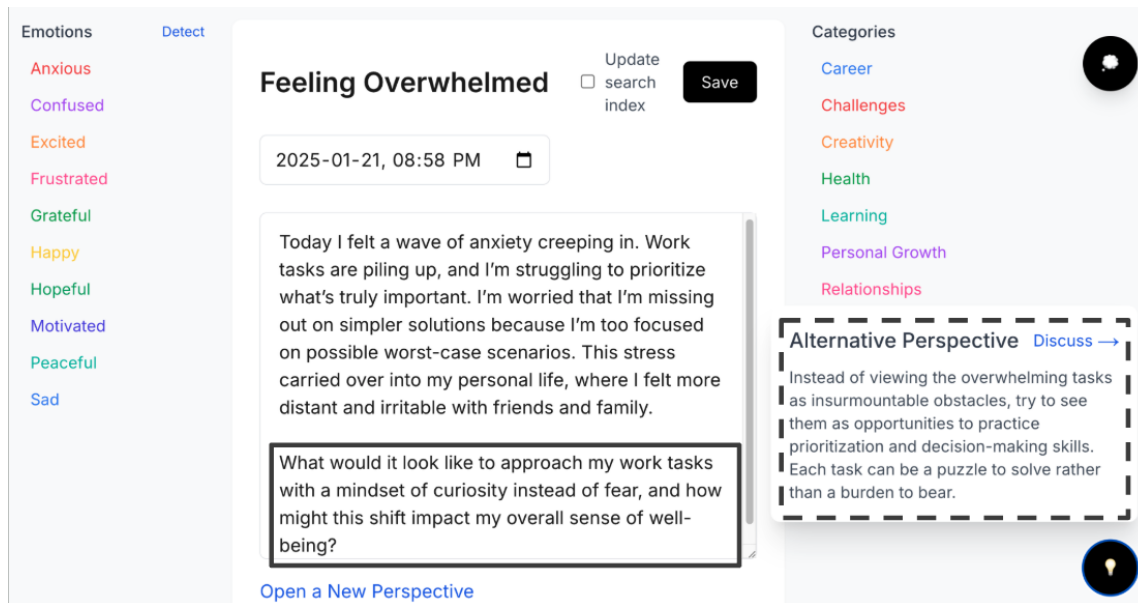


Figure 2: Journaling interface. Reflective prompts are in the solid box and reframing suggestions in the dotted box. Both are LLM generated.

of well-being?” encourages exploration without prescribing solutions.

- **In-the-Moment Chat:** Users can access the LLM-powered chat interface by clicking the chat button (Figure 2). This feature highlights potentially relevant journal excerpts, but the user decides which passages to share, ensuring privacy

and ownership of the reflective process. Shared insights can be added back to the journal.

- **Alternative Perspectives:** The system offers reframing suggestions (dotted box in Figure 2) to help users view challenges from new angles that are generated based on contextual understanding of the entry content.

3.2 Insight Environment

The *Insight Environment* provides a holistic view of journaling history, encouraging long-term reflection and behavioral insights:

- **Visual Summaries and Emotional Tracking:** Users can view their emotional and category metadata as interactive bubble graphs (Figure 3). These graphs illustrate fluctuations in emotional states or highlight recurring patterns such as cycles of anxiety or joy. Users can switch between *Category View* and *Emotion View*, with bubbles linking to related journal entries (Figure 6 in appendix).
- **Semantic Linkages and Reflection Loops:** The system identifies thematic clusters of past entries using semantic embeddings, surfacing connections that may not be immediately apparent. These linkages allow users to use chat interfaces with past experiences. The chatting framework is designed through retrieval-augmented generation (RAG), which combines retrieval of embedded information with LLM’s generation capabilities.
- **Long-Term Trends:** Users can track emotional trajectories, recurring themes, and progress over time, using visualizations to identify patterns and triggers. This empowers users to make gradual, data-informed adjustments to their habits and mindset.

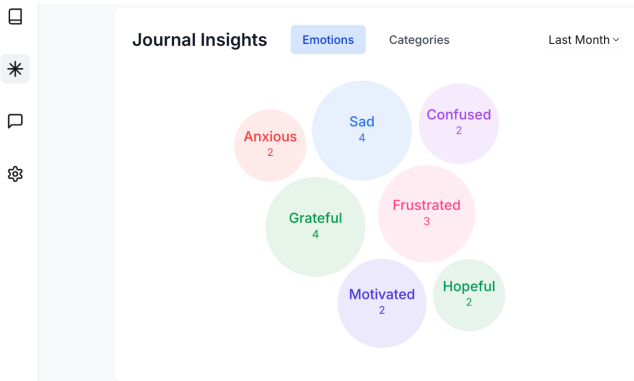


Figure 3: Visual distribution of emotional frequencies. Bubble-style graphs help users identify recurring affective states at a glance.

Both environments are guided by principles of human-centered AI design, focusing on transparency, user control, and ethical handling of sensitive emotional data. These features ensure that the system acts as a facilitator, enabling self-discovery and introspection while avoiding over-reliance on AI suggestions.

3.3 Emphasis on User Agency

A guiding principle throughout the system is that it acts as a facilitator. Users retain final say over emotional tags, extending based on generated contextual questions, and interpretation of AI feedback, thereby reducing risks of AI dependence or superficial engagement.

- **Customizable AI Transparency:** The system clarifies how it arrives at certain suggestions (e.g., tagging a passage as

“anxiety” because of words like “tense” or “overwhelmed”), giving users the option to adjust or reject them.

- **Privacy and Data Minimization:** User data is encrypted, and users can optionally insert the data into the storage to chat with LLM later by toggling the ‘Update Search Index’ box in Figure 2.
- **Non-Directive AI Support:** Prompts provoke thought, not replace it. The user decides how (and whether) to act upon the AI’s feedback.

By weaving these considerations into the system architecture, the *Personal Growth Journal* embodies human-centered AI design and aligns with collaborative intelligence [20] and reflective informatics [3] principles.

4 Design Experience

This section offers qualitative insights from the FA’s lived experience with the system, serving as an autobiographical design probe [5, 6] rather than a traditional user study. The system was developed iteratively over a period of 3 weeks, during which the FA used lived experience to iteratively adapt and tune the features. This section highlights how lived interactions showed both design opportunities and pitfalls.

4.1 Initial Design and Early Insights

The FA began with a journaling practice, entering unstructured text into a generic application over 3 months with 39 entries. Occasionally, off-the-shelf Large Language Model (LLM) tools were consulted for an external perspective on personal emotions and goals. Although sometimes helpful, these LLMs offered generic suggestions, or required significant effort to use with entering context first manually. This lack of context underscored a key need: grounding AI responses in the user’s unique experiences and context can improve the relevance and quality of insights.

Inspired by earlier work on AI-assisted journaling [15] and commercial products such as Mindsera¹, the FA prototyped a simple addition to the journaling interface that:

- Offered reflective prompts guided by a human-in-the-loop philosophy, ensuring the user remained in control.
- Used open-ended questions in addition to the journals to avoid AI “concluding” the user’s experience prematurely.

Although this early version provided reflective prompts, it did not support inquiry into past journal entries.

4.2 Evolving the System Through Lived Interaction

Over time, the FA recognized difficulties in clustering and referencing past experiences effectively. Metadata and labeling are critical for simplifying information retrieval and supporting personal informatics. This motivated the addition of:

- **Automatic Tag Suggestions:** An AI-based engine proposed likely emotional or thematic tags with explanations to reduce manual labeling effort. This aligned with principles of collaborative intelligence [20], where AI augments human capabilities while preserving user oversight.

¹<https://beta.mindsera.com/>

- **Customizable Tags and Explanations:** Recognizing emotional categories vary across individuals, the FA enabled custom label creation. Brief system-generated explanations (e.g., “You seem to express anxiety, does that resonate?”) fostered transparency, helping the FA understand why certain tags were suggested.

Although tagging was introduced in the System Overview, its iterative implementation stemmed from this realization: consistent tagging and transparent AI feedback simplified the FA’s ability to reflect on multiple entries over time. This aligns with findings that emphasize the role of context in fostering deeper reflection [3].

Holistic Insights and Agentic AI Chats. To address the need for deeper, history-aware analysis, the FA integrated a vector store for semantic retrieval. Notably, the system was designed so that:

- **User Consent to Data Sharing:** Before the AI accessed old entries, the FA actively confirmed which excerpts to include, preserving user agency and privacy [13].
- **Reflective Prompts vs. Directives:** Prompts were framed as open-ended questions (e.g., “What changed since you last felt this way?”) to provoke introspection rather than dictate actions, thereby mitigating the risk of over-reliance or superficial engagement similar to tools like Diarymate [15].

Temporary vs. Extended Chats. To accommodate varying emotional needs and time constraints, two modes of AI interaction emerged:

- (1) **Temporary Chat in Entry View:** Quick, context-sensitive conversations during writing. These chats were not saved.
- (2) **Extended Chat with Full History Access:** For deeper reflection, the FA could review previously saved dialogues, enabling longitudinal insight into emotional trends. This is meant to offer a sense of support similar to the slow technology idea [11] for more persistent interactions.

These dual chat modes reflect an evolving design that accommodates in-the-moment feedback while also promoting long-term, data-driven exploration.

4.3 Reflections on Living with the System

Over three weeks of usage, with 15 new entries and a total of 39 prior entries written before the tool’s development, grounding the AI’s suggestions in historical entries significantly enhanced the FA’s self-awareness. Repeated emotional labels (e.g., “anxiety”) surfaced in different contexts, prompting a deeper investigation into potential stress triggers. The dynamic tag suggestions and semantic retrieval also alleviated cognitive load.

The system’s visual *Insight Environment*, which displays emotion and category distributions over different periods, further incentivized the FA to maintain a consistent journaling habit. FA found it particularly useful to observe personal changes in overall mood. Patterns discovered through agentic AI chats led to concrete lifestyle adjustments, such as modifying daily routines or re-evaluating conflict management strategies.

Emotion tagging, which forms the basis of an accurate insight environment, presents challenges:

- (1) Analyzing one’s own emotions is inherently difficult and may be biased. Additionally, manually entering multiple categories requires significant effort.
- (2) Allowing AI to handle tagging or categorization can reduce autonomy and introduce potential misinterpretations.

FA found that for individual entries, AI-driven emotion and category detection was effective.

Example: In one journal entry, the FA expressed anxiety about starting a new chapter in life after leaving the familiar school environment. The AI-generated emotion tags included excitement, sadness, and anxiety (User interface as shown in Figure 4 in the appendix). The FA accepted “excitement” and “anxiety” while rejecting “sadness,” demonstrating both the system’s convenience and the need for user oversight in AI-driven insights. The FA found the explanation for recommended tags to be helpful.

The FA noted an increase in journaling frequency, attributing it to several factors:

- (1) **Engagement:** The personal informatics grouping made self-reflection more engaging and insightful.
- (2) **Ease of Use:** Tagging and writing became simpler, encouraging more frequent entries.
- (3) **Deeper Reflection:** The ability to prompt for feedback, either through predefined insights or customizable AI chats, facilitated richer self-exploration.

However, not all experiences were seamless:

- **Safety and Cognitive Overload:** Open-ended AI chats occasionally strayed into unhelpful or unintended directions, mirroring concerns in HCI about unpredictable AI behavior [21]. Additionally, an increasing number of features introduced usability challenges.
- **Need for Prompt Customization:** While the FA, as a technically inclined user, could manually edit hard-coded AI prompts for quick follow-up questions and alternative perspectives, balancing control for non-technical users remains an open challenge. This highlights future design considerations for prompt transparency and customization [22].

One notable limitation was observed in an *Extend Chat* interaction, where the FA sought a conclusive opinion on their personal state. However, since the chat retrieved information from previous notes, it generated a misleading response, resembling a misdiagnosis based on an earlier entry. This underscores the need for safeguards in AI-generated insights.

Ongoing Refinement. Additional iterations, such as introducing more granular emotional dimensions or integrating further psychological frameworks, remain planned. Overall, the FA’s personal journey with the prototype provided actionable design feedback at each stage, illustrating the possibilities in a human-AI collaborative journaling environment and illustrates the areas where AI can be used to encourage reflection, growth and well being.

5 Discussion

The system’s application in the first author’s (FA) daily life revealed a number of insights that both validate and challenge our original aims. On one hand, the use of emotion tagging proved unexpectedly powerful. By inviting the FA to label (or refine automatically

suggested) emotions, the system encouraged more deliberate introspection, uncovering subtle affective states that might otherwise go unnoticed. On the other hand, certain envisioned outcomes did not fully materialize. Despite the system's focus on agentic AI pipelines, the degree of automation was still perceived by the FA as higher than in purely manual journaling methods, prompting questions about how much "control" truly resides with the user.

Beyond these individual-level observations, broader questions about user diversity and ethical implications remain paramount. An autobiographical design approach inevitably centers on one person's experiences; this system may not generalize to all users with varying emotional needs, technical proficiencies, or cultural contexts. The sensitive nature of emotional content demands careful consideration of privacy, security, and potential AI-driven biases [13, 14]. Even if the system merely suggests reflective prompts, the accumulated data and automated analyses could lead to unintended consequences, such as over-reliance, shallow "pseudo-reflection," or heightened emotional distress if prompts are poorly tuned.

At the same time, the project demonstrates that human-AI collaboration in journaling can be so much more than auto-writing systems and there exist many intermediate levels of AI-assisted introspection. For non-technical users, introducing intuitive tagging, AI recommendations, and AI questions may lower the barriers to sustained reflective practice. Our findings highlight opportunities to reimagine how individuals engage with AI tools to unpack and organize their emotional experiences.

6 Conclusion

In this paper, we introduced an AI-enhanced journaling system that integrates LLM-powered prompts, semantic retrieval, and emotional tagging within a personal informatics framework. We contribute (1) a novel system design that scaffolds deeper introspection through context-aware reflections and user-guided emotional tagging for better personal informatics; (2) lived insights from an autobiographical design approach, revealing key tensions between AI-driven guidance and user autonomy; and (3) preliminary design implications for balancing personalization, privacy, and reflective depth in AI-assisted journaling. Our first-person experiences highlight how grounding AI suggestions in personal contexts can yield richer introspection, yet also raise critical questions around over-reliance, ethical data handling, and emotional well-being.

Looking ahead, we see two immediate avenues for refining these contributions. First, broader user studies and iterative co-design sessions would deepen our understanding of how diverse users navigate the interplay between automated prompts and self-directed journaling. Second, more robust technical safeguards, such as flexible transparency controls and privacy-preserving architectures, will be crucial for safely implementing LLM-based reflection at scale. We hope this early-stage exploration inspires further research on ethical and human-centered AI designs that foster meaningful reflection, emotional resilience, and personal growth.

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A Interface Figures

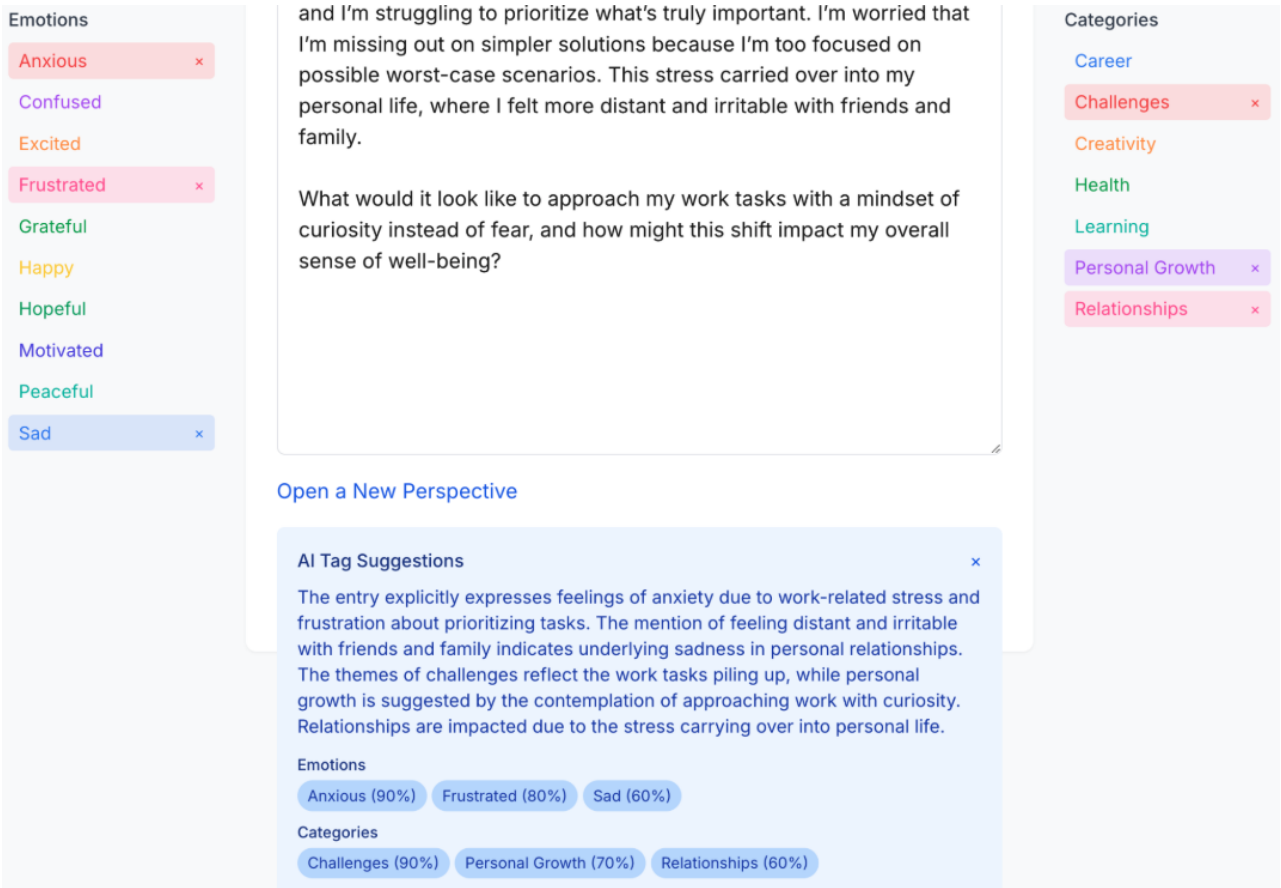


Figure 4: AI-generated emotion tag suggestions with confidence scores. Users can click on recommended tags to maintain agency in labeling.

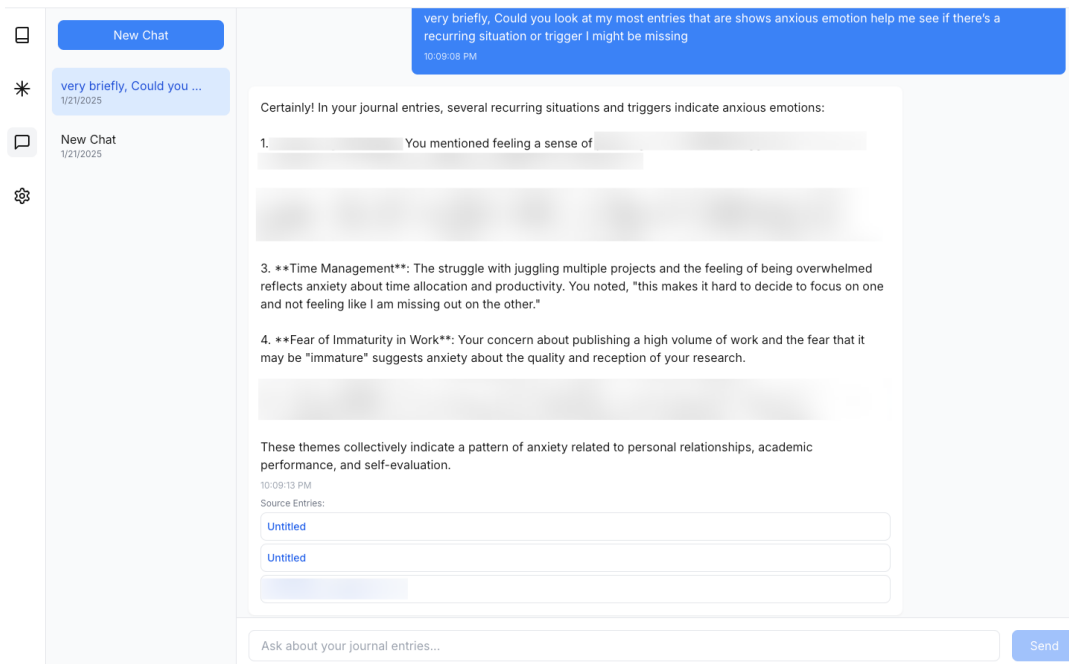


Figure 5: Extended, context-aware chat interface. Users selectively share past entries for retrieval-augmented discussions.

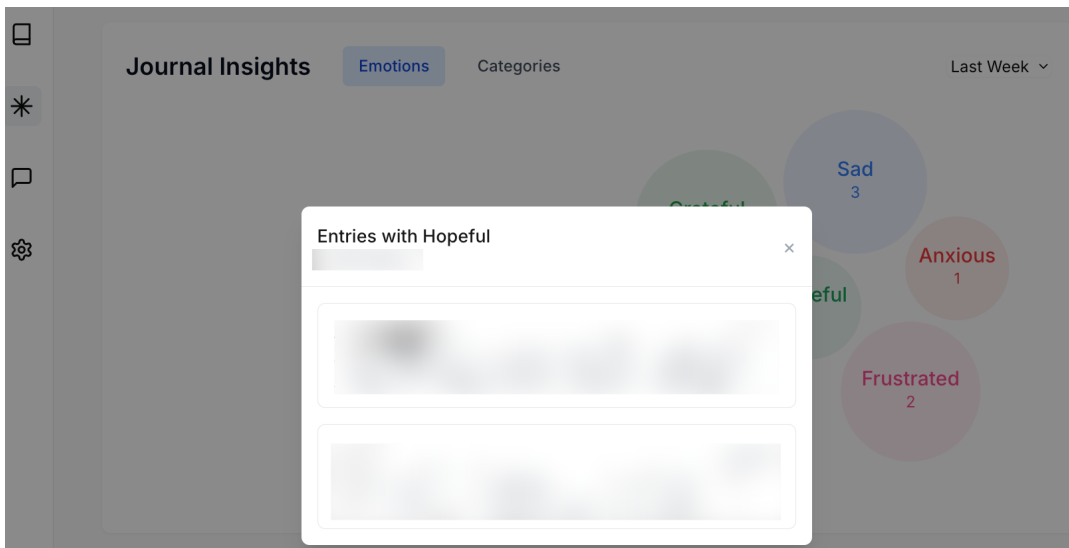


Figure 6: When clicking on a bubble, entries related will be shown in a list.